

LESSON 2

THE NARRATIVE PRESENT: PARTICIPLES AND ENCLITICS

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 1

Quick Summary In Lesson 1, we established the basic building blocks of Syriac syntax. We learned that Syriac sentences do not strictly require a “to be” verb; rather, placing a subject and predicate side-by-side with a matching independent pronoun acts as an equational sentence (e.g.,
MALKĀ HŪ ṬĀBĀ
— “The king [is] good”). We also looked at the absolute versus empathic states of nouns, with the emphatic ending in **ā** (Alaph) acting as the default dictionary form.

5-Question Warm-Up Drill (*Answers in Section 9*) 1. Translate: *Alāhā rabbā hū*. 2. What is the Syriac absolute state for “word” (from *meltā*)? 3. How do you say “We” in Syriac? 4. What particle is used to express “of”, “who”, or “that”? 5. In *Malkūtā d-Alāhā hī*, why is the pronoun *hī* (she) used instead of *hū* (he)?

SECTION 2: THE PARTICIPLE AS PRESENT TENSE — OVERVIEW

In Indo-European languages like English, and Greek, the “present tense” is a fully conjugated finite verb (e.g., “I walk”, *περιπατῶ*). Participles are verbal adjectives (e.g., “the *walking* man”).

In Aramaic and Syriac, the **active participle** stepped in to take over the function of the present tense almost entirely. A Syriac speaker didn’t say “I write” as a finite verb; they literally said “Writing [am] I.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison * **Hebrew:** Biblical Hebrew primarily used the Imperfect for ongoing action, but by the Mishnaic period (interfacing with Aramaic), Hebrew also adopted the participle for the present tense

(e.g., *ānī kōtēb* = I am writing). * **Arabic:** Standard Arabic relies on the imperfect prefix conjugation (يَكْتُبُ *yaktubu*, “he writes”). The active participle (كَاتِبٌ *kātib*) means “writer” or “one who has written,” but does not serve as a primary present tense verb. * **Greek:** Syriac’s reliance on the participle to form continuous action heavily influenced how Syriac translators rendered Greek continuous tenses (often translating a Greek present indicative with a Syriac participle + pronoun).

SECTION 3: THE PEAL ACTIVE PARTICIPLE & ENCLITICS

The Peal Stem Semitic verbs exist in different “stems” (or binyanim) that modify their meaning. The basic, un-augmented ground-stem is called the **Pearl**. Almost all basic actions occur in the Pearl.

Forming the Participle For a strong tri-consonantal root (C-C-C) like *k-t-b* (write), the active participle is formed by inserting a long *ā* after the first consonant, and an *e* after the second. * *kāteb* (writing, m.sg.) * *kātbā* (writing, f.sg.)

Enclitic Pronouns To turn “writing” into “I am writing,” Syriac attaches an **enclitic** pronoun to the back of the participle. Enclitics are shortened, rhythmic versions of the independent pronouns from Lesson 1. * *’enā* (I) → *-nā* * *kāteb* + *-nā* = *kāteb-nā* (I am writing)

SECTION 4: PARTICIPLE AND ENCLITIC PARADIGMS

1. The Enclitic Pronoun Set

PERSON	INDEPENDENT	ENCLITIC FORM	ATTACHED EXAMPLE (KĀTEB)	TRANSLATION
1 c.sg.	ʿenā	-nā	kāteb-nā / kātbā-nā	I am writing
2 m.sg.	ʿant	-t	kāteb-t	You (m) are writing
2 f.sg.	ʿanti	-tī	kātbā-tī	You (f) are writing
3 m.sg.	hū	-hū / (none)*	kāteb / kāteb- hū	He is writing / writes
3 f.sg.	hī	-hī / (none)*	kātbā / kātbā-hī	She is writing / writes
1 c.pl.	ḥnan	-ḥnan	kātbīn-ḥnan / kātbān-ḥnan	We are writing
2 m.pl.	ʿantūn	-tūn	kātbīn-tūn	You (m.pl) are writing
2 f.pl.	ʿantēn	-tēn	kātbān-tēn	You (f.pl) are writing
3 m.pl.	hennōn	(none)**	kātbīn	They (m) are writing
3 f.pl.	hennēn	(none)**	kātbān	They (f) are writing

**In the 3rd person singular, the participle often stands entirely alone without an enclitic. **In the 3rd person plural, the plural suffix (-īn / -ān) is sufficient; no enclitic is added.*

2. The Peal Active Participle Declension (Root **k-t-b**)

GENDER/NUM	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION
Masc. Sg.	ܕܚܒ	kāteb
Fem. Sg.	ܕܚܒܐ	kātbā
Masc. Pl.	ܕܚܒܝܢ	kātbīn
Fem. Pl.	ܕܚܒܝܢܐ	kātbān

SECTION 5: SENTENCE SYNTAX

When the active participle drives the sentence, the word order is very fluid, but Verb-Subject-Object (VSO) or Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) are both common. * **SVO**: *Yūḥannan kāteb meltā*. (Yukhannan writes a word). * **VSO**: *Kāteb Yūḥannan meltā*. (Writes Yukhannan a word). * **Enclitic**: *Kāteb-nā meltā*. (I am writing a word).

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (STRONG VERBS & ADVERBS)

ROOT	PEAL PTCP (M.S.)	MEANING	ADVERB/PARTICLE	MEANING
כ.ת.ב	kāteb	to write	כעת (hāšā)	now
א.ז.ל	ʾāzel	to go	דן (dēn)	but, then, however
א.מ.ר	ʾāmer	to speak/say	תם (tammān)	there
ש.מ.ע	šāmaʿ *	to hear	לל (lʿ el)	above
ר.א.ז	hāzē	to see	הכא (harkā)	here
ע.ב.ד	ʾābed	to do/make	ע (ʿ am)	with
נ.א.ר	nāṭer	to keep/guard	על (ʿ al)	upon, against
ר.ד.פ	rādep	to pursue		
ש.ב.ע	šābeq	to leave		
נ.א.פ	nāpeq	to go out		

*Note: Roots ending in gutturals (like ʿ Ayn) change the **e** to an **a** (šāmaʿ instead of šāmeʿ).

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 2

Preparation Narrative note: The present tense (participle + enclitics) is used here to create an immediate, action-oriented dialogue as Yukhannan prepares his disciples.

Sentence 1 מלך אלהים אומר ללמדיהו Yūḥannan 'āmer l-talmīdē d-
 it l-eh. Yūḥannan (John) 'āmer (is-speaking) l- (to) talmīdē (the-
 disciples) d- (that) it (there-are) l-eh (to-him). → Yukhannan is speaking
 to the disciples that are his.

Sentence 2 אהל נא מנה חקא 'āzel-nā men harkā. 'āzel (going) -nā
 (am-I) men (from) harkā (here). → “I am going from here.”

Sentence 3 אהל נא ללמדיהו אהל נא ל-מלכותא 'āzel-nā l-malkūttā
 d-bīšā, 'āmer-hū. 'āzel (going) -nā (am-I) l- (to) malkūttā (the-kingdom)
 d- (of) bīšā (the-evil-[one]), 'āmer (says) -hū (he). → “I am going to the
 kingdom of the evil one,” he says.

Sentence 4 אהל נא אהל נא אהל נא talmīdē šām ' in meltā d-
 Yūḥannan. talmīdē (the-disciples) šām ' in (are-hearing) meltā (the-word)
 d- (of) Yūḥannan (John). → The disciples hear the word of Yukhannan.

Sentence 5 אהל נא אהל נא אהל נא hennōn 'āmrīn:
 ḥāzēn-ḥnan malkā bīšā tammān. hennōn (they) 'āmrīn (are-saying):
 ḥāzēn (seeing) -ḥnan (are-we) malkā (a-king) bīšā (evil) tammān (there).
 → They say: “We see an evil king there.”

Sentence 6 אהל נא אהל נא אהל נא Yūḥannan 'ābed nūhrā b-
 'ar 'ā. Yūḥannan (John) 'ābed (is-making/doing) nūhrā (light) b- (in)
 'ar 'ā (the-earth). → Yukhannan makes light in the earth.

Sentence 7 אהל נא אהל נא אהל נא kāteb-nā meltā d-
 Alāhā, 'āmer hāšā. kāteb (writing) -nā (am-I) meltā (the-word) d- (of)
 Alāhā (God), 'āmer (says-[he]) hāšā (now). → “I am writing the word of
 God,” he says now.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Participle Identification Identify the gender and number of the following participles. 1. ܕܬܒܝܢ (kātḇīn) 2. ܫܡܝܢܐ (šām ‘ā) 3. ܪܥܦܐ (nāpḡān) 4. ܪܥܦܐ (rādep)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill Combine the root ‘-b-d (to do, make) with the correct enclitic pronoun to form the present tense for: 1. I am making (m.sg) 2. We are making (m.pl) 3. You (f.sg) are making 4. They (m.pl) are making.

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English) Translate the following present tense clauses. 1. ‘āzel-nā l-malkūtā. 2. Šām ‘īn-tūn meltā d-Alāhā. 3. Barnāšā bīšā rādep l-Yūḥannan. 4. Ḥāzēn-ḥnan nūhrā rabbā tammān.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac) Render the following active present sentences into Syriac transliteration. 1. I (m) am hearing the word. 2. She is writing a good word. 3. They (m) are going from here. 4. You (m.pl) are seeing the king.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension Re-read Section 7 and answer: 1. From where does Yukhannan say he is going? 2. What do the disciples fear they will see there? 3. What is Yukhannan “writing” right now?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up 1. God is great. 2. *Melt* (ܡܠܬܐ) 3. ḥnan 4. d- 5. Because *malkūtā* (kingdom) is a feminine noun.

Exercise 1: Participle Identification 1. Masculine Plural 2. Feminine Singular 3. Feminine Plural 4. Masculine Singular

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill 1. ‘ābed-nā 2. ‘ābdīn-ḥnan 3. ‘ābdā-tī 4. ‘ābdīn (no enclitic needed for 3rd person pl)

Exercise 3: Translation Drill 1. I am going to the kingdom. 2. You all are hearing the word of God. 3. The evil man is pursuing Yukhannan. 4. We are seeing a great light there.

Exercise 4: Production Drill 1. Šāma ‘ -nā meltā. 2. Kātbā meltā ṭābtā. 3. ‘ Āzlīn men harkā. 4. Ḥāzēn-tūn l-malkā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension 1. “From here” (*men harkā*). 2. An evil king (*malkā bišā*). 3. The word of God (*meltā d-Alāhā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

PARTICIPLE + ENCLITIC COMBINATIONS (Masc. Root k-t-b)

ENGLISH	PARTICIPLE	ENCLITIC	COMBINED SYRIAC FORM
I write (m)	kāteb	-nā	kāteb-nā
You write (m)	kāteb	-t	kāteb-t
He writes	kāteb	(-hū)	kāteb / kāteb-hū
We write (m)	kātbīn	-ḥnan	kātbīn-ḥnan
You all write (m)	kātbīn	-tūn	kātbīn-tūn
They write (m)	kātbīn	(none)	kātbīn

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson’s vocabulary, focusing on nouns and derived verbal nouns relevant to narrative present (participle) usage.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܠܒܫܐ	lbūšā	m. noun	garment, clothing	from root l-b-š (to wear)
ܕܟܪܢܐ	dəkrānā	m. noun	memory, remembrance	from root d-k-r (to remember)
ܩܥܝܐ	pəg‘ ānā	m. noun	encounter, meeting	from root p-g-‘ (to meet)
ܐܫܒܐ	‘əšb‘ ā	f. noun	finger	body part, abstract
ܩܠܫܐ	pūlhānā	m. noun	labor, toil	from root p-l-ḥ (to serve)
ܫܡܪܢܐ	šəmrānā	m. noun	guard, watchfulness	from root š-m-r (to guard)
ܕܠܘܬܐ	gəmalūtā	f. noun	kindness, mercy	from root g-m-l (to treat well)
ܠܓܕܬܐ	ləgdəttā	f. noun	overtaking, capture	from root l-g-d (to reach)
ܕܠܘܬܐ	dəlūtā	f. noun	poverty, want	abstract noun
ܩܠܕܐ	pəlgūtā	f. noun	division, share	from root p-l-g (to divide)
ܩܠܦܐ	qəlpəttā	f. noun	shell, exterior	
ܪܘܓܝܐ	rūgzānā	m. noun	rage, wrath	from root r-g-z (to shake)
ܕܝܕܐ	ydā‘ ūttā	f. noun	knowledge	from root y-d-‘ (to know)
ܩܦܪܐ	kəprā	m. noun	village, hamlet	place noun
ܩܦܪܐ	pəqrā	m. noun	opening, aperture	from root p-q-r (to open)
ܕܠܘܬܐ	gəmrūtā	f. noun	completion, fulfillment	from root g-m-r (to complete)
ܩܘܫܐ	ṭūšānā	m. noun	strength, might	from root ṭ-w-š (to be strong)
ܫܦܐ	šəp‘ ā	m. noun	abundance, plenty	from root š-p-‘ (to suffice)
ܠܡܐ	lahmā	m. noun	bread, food	staple item

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܦܫܡܐ	pəsmā	m. noun	measure, standard	
ܫܠܡܘܬܬܐ	šəlmūttā	f. noun	completeness, wholeness	from root š-l-m (to be whole)
ܥܠܩܐ	‘alqā	m. noun	ascent, stairway	from root ‘-l-q (to ascend)
ܥܬܪܢܐ	gaṭrānā	m. noun	enclosure, fence	from root g-ṭ-r (to fence)
ܫܢܘܬܬܐ	šənūttā	f. noun	change, alteration	from root š-n-y (to change)
ܕܒܩܘܬܬܐ	dəbqūttā	f. noun	clinging, adherence	from root d-b-q (to cling)
ܩܕܘܫܘܬܬܐ	qdūšūttā	f. noun	holiness, sanctity	from root q-d-š (to be holy)
ܕܥܠܘܬܬܐ	gdūlūttā	f. noun	greatness, grandeur	from root g-d-l (to be great)
ܥܪܘܬܬܐ	‘ərūttā	f. noun	nakedness, shame	from root ‘-r-y (to be naked)
ܕܒܪܢܐ	dəbrānā	m. noun	word, matter	related to d-b-r
ܪܡܘܬܬܐ	rūmūttā	f. noun	height, elevation	from root r-w- m (to be high)